ગુજરાતી શિક્ષણ સંઘ

Consortium of Gujarati Schools

https://www.gujaratischools.org/

# Notes of the BGM held on Sunday 22nd May 2022 at Ekta Centre

**Members present:** Jayantbhai Tanna (Chair), Vijyaben Bhanderi (Secretary), Rekhaben Patel (Treasurer) and 37 other members. See attached list.

**Apologies received:**

## 1. Welcome

The Chairman, Jayantbhai Tanna welcomed today's guests, Mr C B Patel and Maheshbhai Kaloriya from Gujarat Samachar, and all members present.

After a short prayer – and silence for the departed souls due to Covid-19, Jayantbhai outlined format of today's meeting.

## 2 Notes of the last meeting – 19th July 2020 (circulated in advance via email)

The Notes/Minutes of the last BGM were accepted unanimously.
These were approved by Tusharbhai and seconded by Rekhaben Shah.

## 3. Matters arising

### (a) Organisational and Individual Membership

Vijyaben reported that for 2020-2022 CGS received 6 individual and 8 (4+2+1+1) organisational membership subscriptions.

The forms for the 2022-24 subscriptions will be emailed shortly. These should be made as soon as possible. Organisation Membership is £25 per school and Individual Membership has been reduced to £10 per member.

Jayantbhai requested each Organisation to pay their subscription for each Gujarati School and nominate up to 3 members to represent them as CGS members as per our Rules. He also requested all other teachers and volunteers, who were not nominated to become Individual Members by paying £10.

### (b) School Information Forms

Vijyaben Bhanderi, the Secretary, explained the importance of collecting information about the number of pupils learning Gujarati and the numbers taking GCSE Gujarati every year in our schools.

It is this kind of information that helps us to see the progress we are making and what we need to do to improve further.

Due to Covid-19 lockdowns, some schools closed and others conducted virtual classes. As a result, CGS did not receive much data from Gujarati Schools during 2020-2022.

Vijyaben said that updated School Information Forms would be sent out at the beginning of the new academic year. She requested all Gujarati schools to complete and return these forms by the stated deadline, together with leaflet about the schools.

The leaflet could include information about their school e.g. the days, times and duration of lessons, the age range, the strengths and achievements, their location and contact information etc. similar to those of mainstream school websites. Nice pictures of class activities and programmes would be a bonus. These can be added to the website so that parents and others can visit the website to get information about Gujarati schools for their children.

**(c) CGS Website** www.gujaratischools.org

Jayantbhai displayed CGS website and went through the contents of the CGS Website, which is quite resourceful and includes very useful information, resources for both teachers and parents, past GCSE papers, which can be downloaded. However, Jayantbhai stressed that it is not used as much as it should be.

Nirmalbhai suggested that the data from CGS Schools Information forms about the number of children studying in Gujarati schools and sitting for GCSE and A levels should also be included on the Website. This information would be useful for Gujarati Community.

The website should be publicised in a big way outside, i.e. on open days of the Gujarati schools for parents.

**(d) Examination Centres**

Jayantbhai informed the meeting about the extreme difficulties our children were having in getting centres for GCSE Gujarati exams, even in their own schools. In view of the lack of support from mainstream schools in many areas willing to accept external candidates for GCSE exams, he suggested that organisations which had their own buildings and facilities to become examination centres.

**4. Report for 2020 – 2022 (circulated in advance via email)**

Jayantbhai went through the report outlining the various activities and undertaken by CGS.

**(a) Teachers' Training Zoom Sessions**

Jayantbhai briefed about the trainings provided to teachers via zoom sessions, regarding GCSE exams situation during the Covid-19 lockdown.

Following the cancellation of summer GCSE exams, Candidates could not sit for face-to-face exams and GCSE teachers were required to submit Teacher Assessed Grades (TAGs) based on the candidates' work assessed as evidence for Listening, Reading and Writing. GCSE teachers were also required to submit Endorsed Grades to the Exam Board for Speaking Skills.

The aim of the zoom sessions was to discuss the types of TAG evidence for the three skills and Endorsement Criteria set by Pearson Exam Board for assessing the Speaking Skills for GCSE. Teachers were given examples of what could be submitted as evidence Listening, Reading and Writing, and what could be considered as Pass, Merit and Distinction grades for Speaking. The session was quite successful.

**(b) Candidates sitting for GCSE Gujarati Exams**

Jayantbhai also reflected on the number of candidates sitting for GCSE exams had dropped considerably, possibly due to the virtual lessons conducted during the lockdown period.

**5. Treasurer's Report (circulated in advance via email)**

Rekhaben Patel, Treasurer, presented a report on CGS's financial situation.

She went through the items of Income and Expenditure and explained that our balance at present was a healthy amount of £2400 as at 31st March 2022.

The income for during 2020-2022 period was less and very few organisational and Individual membership subscriptions were received.

Expenditure was only £50 paid for NRCSE membership. No other expenses were incurred.

The Report was approved and accepted unanimously.

## 6. Proposed changes to the Rules of CGS (circulated in advance via email)

Jayantbhai explained the proposed changes for the continuity and to for CGS Committee to work in harmony in order to facilitate the progression of CGS. The two additional posts are Vice Chairperson and Immediate past Chairperson and Secretary as and when required.

The proposed changes were approved and accepted unanimously.

Nirmalbhai suggested setting up a board of advisors, a body that could look at how CGS can build relationship with the Gujarati Community at large and bringing to their attention CGS activities and further CGS objectives.

Jayantbhai suggested this could be at the next stage, at the next BGM.

## 7. Election of the new CGS Committee for 2020 - 2022

Only one nomination for each of the posts of Chair, Secretary, and Treasurer were received. These were Sonalben R Shah for Chairperson, Vijyaben Bhanderi for Secretary and Rekhaben Patel for Treasurer. They were all duly elected.

For the seven committee positions, three nominations were received in advance from Hasvinaben Shah, Rekhaben L Shah (Mandhata) and Prafulaben Shah. Further nominations were received during the election from Radhaben Patel, Riddhiben Patel, Jatinbahi Shah and Veljibhai Vekaria.

All the above three were elected unanimously.

Following the changes to the CGS Rules, Tusharbhai Shah was elected as Vice Chairperson and Jayantbhai Tanna as Immediate Past Chairperson.

CGS can appoint three more co-opted committee members at a later if need be.

## 8. Planning for the Future

### (a) Address by Mr CB Patel

Mr CB Patel briefly addressed the audience. He stressed that our identity and culture can only survive if our mother tongue Gujarati can be retained, even if it is used just for communication. Gujaratis have done well in all fields; however, they need to do more for the retention of their heritage language.

He was very impressed with the CGS activities and what it has achieved in the last seven years and agreed to support CGS with publicity via ABPL weekly newspapers.

### Address by new Chairperson – Sonalben

Sonalben put forward her vision as Chairperson for the future

- find GCSE centres for external candidates sitting for GCSE Gujarati exams;
- offer training to teachers/examiners conducting GCSE Speaking exams;
- offer teachers training to teach Gujarati at different levels;

## 9. Any Other Business

Members of the audience put forward the following suggestions for the betterment of CGS activities

- Jatinbhai Shah suggested in order to attract our young parents and familiarise them about our cultural heritage and language, big organisations can organise big events.
- Dhirenbhai Shah – there is a shortage of teachers as the older generations are now retiring. More training should be organised for the new teachers, especially to teach younger children.
- Nirmalbhai Shah– perhaps organise field/student exchange trips to Gujarat similar to those organised in the mainstream schools. Some members from the audience responded by saying whilst it may be possible in mainstream schools, for Gujarati Schools this may not be possible as this would incur a great deal of planning, parental involvement, insurance etc. Sonalben suggested that local field trips in UK should be considered by large community schools.
- Kantaben Shah – explained that Gujarati alphabet is arranged in a scientific manner and if taught correctly, children's pronunciation can be much improved. She also suggested more should be done to have adult classes in Gujarati Schools. Vijyaben responded by saying that many schools have tried the adult classes and also encouraged students to sit for GCSE, however, as adult students have many other responsibilities, they often are not able to continue.
- Rajveeben Punatar – suggested data collection from where people are logging in on website

## 10. Vote of Thanks & Close

Vijyaben thanked everyone - Ekta Centre, guests and all those who attended the meeting attendance on a lovely Sunday afternoon! She hoped to get their dedication and support in the same way in the future.
The meeting closed at approximately at 5.00 pm.

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| Chair | Secretary | Date |

# Attendance - Biennial Meeting - 22 May 2022

| No | Forename | Organisation | Position |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Jayantbhai Tanna | CGS Individual Member | CGS Chairperson |
| | Vijyaben Bhanderi | CGS Individual Member | CGS Secretary |
| | Rekhaben Patel | Harrow - Shishukunj | CGS Treasurer |
| | Sonalben R Shah | Individual member / OAUK NW Education portfolio | CGS Committee |
| | Tusharbhai Shah | OAUK | CGS Committee |
| | C B Patel | Asian Business Publications Ltd - Gujarat Samachar | Editor in Chief - Guest |
| | Maheshbhai Liloriya | Asian Business Publications Ltd - Gujarat Samachar | Group Editor - Guest |
| 1. | Ritaben Kamdar | Alperton Community School (mainstream) | Teacher |
| 2. | Kanchanben K Shah | Shishukunj, Harrow & OAUK NW Area Gujarati School | Teacher |
| 3. | Jagdishbhai Shah | Individual | |
| 4. | Kantaben Shah | Individual | |
| 5. | Radhaben Patel | Individual | |
| 6. | Hansaben Bhatt | Mandhata Youth & Community Association | Teacher |
| 7. | Prabhaben Jivan | Mandhata Youth & Community Association | Head Teacher & CGS Committee Member |
| 8. | Yashuben Patel | Mandhata Youth & Community Association | Teacher |
| 9. | Rekhaben Shah | Mandhata Youth & Community Association | Co-ordinator & CGS Committee Member |
| 10. | Nirmalbhai Shah | Oshwal Association of the UK (OAUK) | OAUK Committee Member |
| 11. | Rajubhai Shah | OAUK | Guest |
| 12. | Rajveeben Punatar (Dr) | OAUK | Central Education Portfolio |
| 13. | Dhaneshbhai Shah | OAUK North West Area Gujarati School | OAUK NW committee |
| 14. | Nikaetaben Shah | OAUK North West Area Gujarati School | OAUK NW committee |
| 15. | Harkhubhai Haria | OAUK North West Area Gujarati School | Teacher |
| 16. | Nirmalaben Haria | OAUK North West Area Gujarati School | Teacher |
| 17. | Prafulaben Shah | OAUK North West Area Gujarati School | Secretary |
| 18. | Dinaben Shah | OAUK West Area Gujarati School | Teacher |
| 19. | Maheshbhai Velji Shah | OAUK West Area Gujarati School | Co-ordinator |
| 20. | Sejalben Shah | OAUK West Area Gujarati School | Teacher |
| 21. | Shobhana Shah | OAUK West Area Gujarati School | Teacher |
| 22. | Dinaben Bhudia | Pandav Vidya Shala | Head Teacher |
| 23. | Jatinbhai Shah | Pandav Vidya Shala | Curriculum assistant |
| 24. | Rahulbhai Patel | Pandav Vidya Shala | Treasurer |
| 25. | Riddhiben Patel | Pandav Vidya Shala | Co-ordinator |

| No | Forename | Organisation | Position |
|---|---|---|---|
| 26. | Laljibhai Ladwa | Pandav Vidya Shala | Co-ordinator |
| 27. | Dhanuben Varsani | Shishukunj - Kenton | Teacher |
| 28. | Dhirenbhai Shah | Shishukunj - Kenton | Co-ordinator |
| 29. | Pushpaben Vekaria | Shishukunj - Kenton | Teacher |
| 30. | Veljibhai Vekaria | Shree Kutch Leva Patel Community (UK) (SKLPC) | President |
| 31. | Jasuben Jesani | SKLPC Saturday School | Head teacher |
| 32. | Jeetendrabhai Vaghjiani | SKLPC Saturday School | Co-ordinator |
| 33. | Kanchanben K Shah | Shree Kutch Satsang Swaminarayan Temple Kenton Gujarati School | Teacher |